

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 3

New Patient: Meera – Highly Detailed Version
Full Detailed – Realistic Style with Greater Depth

SESSION INFORMATION

Client:	Meera (28 years, Female, High School Teacher, Therapist)	Therapist:	Dr. A.
Session #:	3 of 16–18	Focus:	Behavioral Activation + Deeper Cognitive Work

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client arrived looking visibly tired. She spoke in a low, flat tone and avoided eye contact at the beginning of the session. She completed the diary on only 4 out of 7 days and managed only one small activity. She expressed strong self-criticism and hopelessness. Today's plan: Explore her experience with homework in depth, introduce Behavioral Activation with very small steps, continue cognitive restructuring with more Socratic exploration, and assign manageable homework.

SESSION START – CHECKING IN

Therapist: Good morning, Meera. It's good to see you. How have you been feeling since we last met?

Client: (speaking softly, looking down) Not great. I tried to do the diary but only managed 4 days. And the activity... I only did it once. I feel like I'm already failing at this. I don't know why I even came today.

Therapist: (speaking gently) It sounds like this week has been really heavy for you. I can hear a lot of frustration and self-criticism in what you're saying. Can you tell me a bit more about how it felt when you couldn't complete the homework?

Client: (voice cracking slightly) It just made me feel worse about myself. Like even this small thing I can't do. I already feel like I'm a bad teacher, and now I can't even do therapy properly. What's the point?

Therapist: That sounds incredibly painful — feeling like you're failing at everything, including trying to get help. I want you to know that what you're describing is very common when someone is depressed. The low energy and harsh self-judgment are part of the depression itself, not proof that you're failing. Would it be okay if we looked at this together without judging it too quickly?

Client: (nodding slightly, still looking down) Okay...

HOMEWORK REVIEW – EXPLORING THE EXPERIENCE

Therapist: You mentioned you only managed the diary on 4 days and one small activity. Can you walk me through what happened on the days you couldn't do it? What got in the way?

Client: Most evenings I would come home from school feeling completely drained. I would think about writing in the diary, but then this voice in my head would say "What's the point? Nothing is going to change anyway." So I would just lie on the bed and scroll on my phone or stare at the ceiling.

Therapist: That voice saying "What's the point?" sounds very powerful. When that thought came up, how did it make you feel emotionally and in your body?

Client: Hopeless. Heavy. Like there's no point in even trying. My body would feel even more tired.

Therapist: And when you felt that way, what did you end up doing?

Client: Nothing. I would just stay in bed until I fell asleep or it got late.

Therapist: So the thought "What's the point?" led to strong hopelessness, which then led to withdrawing and doing nothing. This is a very common cycle in depression. Does seeing it like this make any sense to you?

Client: (quietly) Yeah... it does. I never really thought about it that way before.

INTRODUCING BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION – GENTLY

Therapist: Given how heavy everything has been feeling, I'd like to talk about something called Behavioral Activation, but I want to be very careful with it because I know your energy is very low right now. When people are depressed, they often stop doing even small things that used to give them a tiny bit of relief or sense of achievement. This creates a cycle where low activity leads to even lower mood. The idea is to gently add back very small activities — not to "fix" everything, but to slowly break that cycle. Would it be okay if we explored this together?

Client: (sighing) I don't know... even thinking about doing something feels exhausting. But I guess I can listen.

Therapist: Thank you for being open. We're not going to add big activities. We're going to think about things that take only **5 minutes or less**. Things that might feel slightly doable even on hard days. What are some very small things that might fit into your day — even if they don't feel enjoyable right now?

Client: (thinking for a while) Maybe... making a cup of tea mindfully. Or stepping outside for 5 minutes after school. But I don't know if I'll actually do it.

Therapist: Those are excellent suggestions. And it's completely okay if you don't manage to do them every day. The goal is not perfection — it's gentle movement. Even if you do it once or twice this week, that's still progress. How does that feel?

Client: A bit less overwhelming than before. But I'm still not sure I'll have the energy.

CONTINUING COGNITIVE RESTRUCTURING

Therapist: Last session we looked at the thought “I’m not good enough as a teacher.” During the session, your belief in it dropped from 80% to 40%. During the week, it went back up to around 65–70%. How much do you believe it right now?

Client: Around 65%. It’s still there. Especially after difficult days at school.

Therapist: That’s very normal. These thoughts often get louder when we’re tired or when something difficult happens. Can we look together at what evidence supports this thought and what might go against it — even a little?

Client: (quietly) I guess some students still seem to like my classes. And one parent recently thanked me for helping their child. But it’s hard to hold on to those things when I feel so tired.

Therapist: That makes a lot of sense. When we’re depressed, our brain tends to focus much more on the negative evidence and filters out the positive. This is called a “negative bias.” It doesn’t mean the positive things aren’t real — it just means depression makes them harder to notice. Does that resonate with you at all?

Client: Yeah... it does. I can see how I focus on the bad things and ignore the small good things.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week, I want to keep things as manageable as possible:

1. Continue the daily mood + thought diary (even 4 entries is fine)
2. Try 2–3 very small activities this week (only 5 minutes max) — things like making tea mindfully or stepping outside
3. Notice one small thing you did accomplish each day (even brushing your teeth or reaching school on time) and write it down
4. Continue rating your belief in the thought “I’m not good enough as a teacher” and gently using the balanced thought we created

Client: I’ll try... but I’m still not sure how much energy I’ll have.

Therapist: That’s completely okay. Just do what you can. We’ll work with whatever you bring next time, without judgment.

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we explored your experience with the homework in more depth, introduced Behavioral Activation very gently, and looked at how depression affects what we notice. How are you feeling about today’s session?

Client: It was okay. I still feel very tired, but talking about it helped a bit. I’ll try the small activities.

Therapist: That’s completely fair. Any questions before we finish?

Client: Not really.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client arrived with visible fatigue and strong self-criticism. Emotional depth was higher than previous sessions.
- Behavioral Activation introduced very gently with 5-minute activities due to extremely low energy.
- Client showed some insight into negative bias but remains skeptical about improvement.
- Belief in core thought remains stable around 65%.
- Next session: Review behavioral activation attempts with compassion, continue cognitive restructuring with more depth, explore values or small sources of meaning if appropriate.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.